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 - Secrets of 370 Jay Exhibition
 - Transit Museum
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TIME CAPSULE - buried in 1950, opened in October 2014 - [NY Daily News](#)

A time capsule buried at the former NYC Transit Headquarters in Brooklyn in 1950 proved to be just like the subway: porous, leaky and rusty.

There was a nickel, some badly deteriorated newspapers and a glass box that was believed to have microfilm of the original construction drawings of 370 Jay St. that experts believe won't be salvageable

Experts on hand said nothing in the time capsule appeared salvageable — except for a nickel.



Steelwork completion in 1949, Mayor O'Dwyer alleges that Transit Unification in 1940 was a dirty deal. [Brooklyn Eagle](#)

O'Dwyer attacked the unification deal that had been completed under his predecessor, La Guardia.

He stated it would cost city's taxpayers 700 million rather than the originally stated 300 million, with the additional 400 million to be paid out over the next 40 years to bond holders who have been guaranteed a 3% tax exempt return on their investment.

His comments were likely a distraction from the growing police scandal surrounding his own administration.

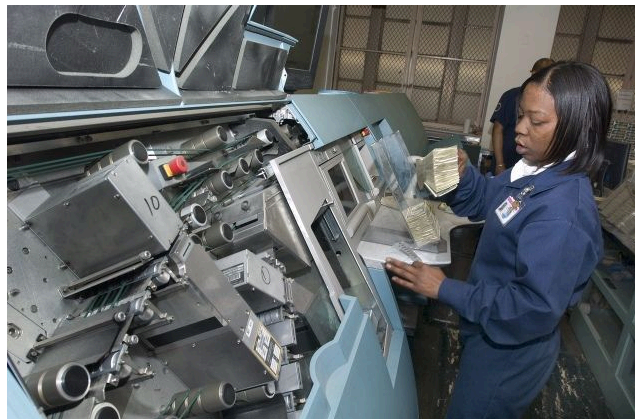
Political observers today awaited Newbold Morris' reaction to Mayor O'Dwyer's charge that the Republican-Liberal Mayorality candidate had approved what the Mayor termed a "dirty" transit unification deal of 1940.

Climaxing a whirlwind speech-making tour of the city, the Mayor declared at ceremonies marking the steel-work completion of the new Board of **Transportation Building** at Jay and Willoughby Sts. that his predecessor in City Hall had signed transit unification contracts that would eventually cost the city's taxpayers \$700,000,000, rather than the original price of \$300,000,000.

The additional \$400,000,000, O'Dwyer said, would be paid out during the next 40 years to bond holders who have been guaranteed a 3 percent tax exempt return on their investment.

Untapped Cities 370 Jay Street was built in 1951 as part of the post-World War II Brooklyn Civic Center Urban Renewal project.

The building once had cool aspects such as a **secret second floor elevator used to transport money, the Subway Command Center, and a Lost and Found Department containing abandoned umbrellas.**



A Money Room employee uses the GPS 1000 high speed mixed currency counter and sorter to process 30 bills per second, 2006. Credit: Patrick Cashin / MTA New York City Transit



Another view of the cramped data processing rooms, 1957. Courtesy of the New York Transit Museum

In 2012, New York University and the city of New York agreed to renovate the building into a sustainable hub for NYU's growing engineering programs.

[Brooklyn Eagle](#)

October 2015 - "The Secret Life of 370 Jay Street" will reveal the inner workings and the quirky history of one of New York's first mid-century modern office buildings.



Rendering from the Board of Transportation Annual Report, 1949. Photo courtesy of the New York Transit Museum

Its 420 perfectly uniform windows hid a secret elevator used to move cash from fare collection trains to the Money Room on the second floor.

In 2012 the City of New York and New York University entered into an agreement to transform 370 Jay St. into a modern, sustainable academic center that will be the foundation of the University's expanding engineering and applied sciences programs, including their Center for Urban Science and Progress

aiany.org - The 370 Jay Street project is three stories in one: the LEED Platinum renovation of a mid-century building with sustainability as a key goal; advancement of a new academic trajectory for a leading university; and a partnership between the University and the City.

[Altas Obscura](#)

Falling into disrepair - The [Brooklyn Eagle](#) shortlisted it as one of the borough's ugliest buildings. And, as a 2012 *New York Times* piece about its renovation noted, "it is pretty much impossible to love the Transportation Building."

HEIST! - One Saturday morning in 1979, there was a planned blackout at 370 Jay as part of a drill. Even though extra guards were posted at the Money Room, the robbers got their way. “Monday morning, people walk in, they open the vault, and \$600,000 is missing,” Harmon says. All of the ten-dollar bills were gone, 120 pounds worth. Officials scrambled to figure out what happened.

They found an escape hole in the wall of the adjacent women’s bathroom and tracked the thieves to a hotel room in New Jersey, where they found an empty bag marked “Transit Authority.” After an initial investigation that reportedly focused on someone inside the transit agency, officials eventually put out a \$25,000 reward to catch the suspects. But they were never caught and the money was never returned.

The elaborate fare collection apparatus wasn’t the only way 370 Jay Street’s form mirrored its function. It had entire rooms dedicated to phone equipment with people who manually connected calls.

Lost and Found Items - It housed a lost and found, which saw hundreds of umbrellas, tubas, a pheasant, and a jar full of ashes labeled “my dear wife Ada.”

<https://nyu.manifoldapp.org/read/runbin-final-project/section/894372bb-92ce-40f9-bcb0-4a969522c460>

The building was designed not only to consolidate more than fifty departments but also to streamline fare collection by **allowing collection trains to run directly into the structure**. This would eliminate the need for armored trucks to transport fare boxes through city streets. The relocation was part of a **broader effort by Mayor Fiorello La Guardia to decentralize city agencies and distribute municipal functions more evenly across the five boroughs** (The New York Times, 1939)

CITY SUBWAY BOARD TO GET NEW HOME

Will Leave Rented Quarters in
Hudson St. for Building in
Brooklyn Next Year

The Board of Transportation will move, on or before Jan. 1, 1940, from its present rented quarters at 250 Hudson Street to a fourteen-story home of its own at the corner of Jay and Willoughby Streets in Brooklyn, it was disclosed yesterday.

The new building, to be erected on city-owned land, will be especially planned to suit the purposes of the board. It will be directly over the Willoughby-Jay Street station of the Independent Subway System.

A feature of the new structure will be a type of construction which will permit collection cars to be run from the subway tracks directly into the building. This will eliminate the present system of having collections made by armored trucks which must traverse the city's streets to reach the present headquarters of the board.

The site for the board's new home is one of the numerous tracts left in possession of the city after it had condemned privately owned property for subway construction purposes. It has a frontage of 83 feet on Willoughby Street and 500 feet on Jay Street. The lot is now being used for parking purposes.

The board has already notified the owners of the property at 250 Hudson Street that it will not renew its lease of those premises.

Before deciding upon the Brooklyn site the board rejected a proposal that it take over the building at 15 Park Row. Another site rejected was a tract owned by the city at West Houston Street and Broadway.

The removal of the board's headquarters to Brooklyn, it is understood, is in line with Mayor La Guardia's desire for the more even distribution of city department offices among the various boroughs.

The plan of 370 Jay Street started around 1940. At that time, a newspaper article reported that the New York City Transit Board wanted to build a new office building in Brooklyn. **The plan was to construct a 15-story structure that would cost \$3.8 million**(Based on BLS estimates, \$3.8 million in 1940 would be worth nearly \$87.5 million in today's dollars). The building was intended to serve as a central office for the city's transit system (Brooklyn Daily Eagle, 1940).

TRANSIT BOARD TO HAVE 15-STORY BORO BUILDING

Orders Plans for Jay St.
\$3,800,000 Structure
To House Central Office

Detailed plans for the Board of Transportation's new central office building in Brooklyn were announced today by W. Jerome Daly, secretary of the board.

A contract has been signed by the board with the firm of Eggers & Higgins, architects, of 542 5th Ave., Manhattan, for preparing studies, drawings, specifications and estimates for a building to cost not more than \$3,800,000. The architects' contract price is \$36,000.

The new building will house the central operating departments of the three divisions of the New York City rapid transit system, the lost property department and the central police station of the system.

The ground floor will be arranged to accommodate a bank, and the sub-basement will be constructed with a platform connection to the subway tracks of the Jay-Smith St. line for unloading the revenue cars.

On City-Owned Property

The building lobby will have a stairway connecting with the mezzanine of the Jay St. Borough Hall station of the former Independent System, now known as the IND Division.

The building will be erected on city-owned property along the west



BOARD OF TRANSPORTATION'S NEW BUILDING in Brooklyn, seen here in an architect's sketch by the firm of Eggers & Higgins, will house the central offices of the board, thus becoming the nerve center of the city's augmented rapid transit system.

During World War II, the construction of 370 Jay Street was **significantly postponed as a direct consequence of wartime mobilization**. The federal government imposed strict rationing policies on essential construction materials, especially steel, copper, and concrete, which were redirected to support military production such as ships and aircraft. **Civilian building projects across the country, including the planned headquarters of the Board of Transportation in Brooklyn, were considered nonessential and had to be delayed**. At the same time, the labor force was reduced because many skilled workers were drafted or voluntarily joined the armed forces. Others shifted to wartime industries such as weapons manufacturing and shipbuilding. These combined shortages of materials and labor made it impossible for the BOT to move forward with construction during the war. It was only after the conflict ended, when materials became available again and the construction workforce returned, that the project resumed in 1948.

The original budget had nearly doubled to \$7 million(Based on BLS estimates, \$7 million in 1948 would be worth nearly \$94.5 million in today's dollars), and the **number of floors was reduced to 13** (The New York Times, 1948). Construction began in the summer of that year.



Money Transit Train Used at Jay Street Station





Questions for Tanika:

Archival Resources

Blueprints